

Permissiveness versus conservatism in ontology

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

Prof. Cian Dorr

9th September 2026

Permissive views of material-object ontology

Three dimensions of permissiveness.

1. Permissiveness at a time. EG: For any collection of material objects, there is a material object that spatially includes all of them, and doesn't spatially include anything that doesn't spatially overlap them.
2. Permissiveness across time. EG: For any function from some instants of time to material objects, there is an object that exists at exactly those times and coincides at each time with the associated object.
3. Modal permissiveness. EG: For any function from some possible worlds to material objects, there is an object that exists at exactly those worlds and coincides at each world with the associated object.

Spatiotemporalism and permissiveness

We have already considered two highly permissive views.

- ▶ Spatiotemporalism—the view that material objects just are regions of spacetime—is permissive in the first two ways, though not modally.
- ▶ The view that material objects just are *properties of spacetime points* is permissive in all three ways.

In this unit, we'll be looking at the more general family of views with a permissive flavor.

“Eliminative” and “conservative” alternatives to permissivism

We can make a rough-and-ready distinction between two kinds of alternative to a permissivist view (along a given dimension):

Eliminative views say that there are *very few* material objects.

For example, some philosophers have argued for a view called ‘mereological nihilism’, according to which *there are no composite objects*—understood as entailing that there are no tables, no galaxies, no plants or animals—maybe even no people. Just ‘atoms and the void’, or spacetime points (or what have you).

Conservative views try to stake out a middle ground—one that accepts a wide range of familiar objects (and thus avoids having to say that our ordinary talk about the physical world is full of error) but rejects the sweeping generalizations that permissivists accept.

Korman's “particularism”

Korman favours a methodological approach he calls ‘particularism’:

Particularism about a given domain of inquiry is the view that our intuitive judgments about cases in the domain are largely correct and that, when intuitive judgments about cases conflict with compelling general principles, the cases should in general be treated as counterexamples to those principles. [Korman, ‘Strange Kinds’, 119–20]

According to Korman, ‘our intuitive judgments’ conflict sharply with all forms of permissivism.

Common sense and intuitive judgments

There are a few different kinds of judgments one might worry about conflicting with.

1. Ordinary beliefs expressed in everyday discourse—‘The island gets much bigger when the tide goes out’.
2. Things non-philosophers are disposed to say when presented with philosophical puzzles or generalizations.
3. ‘[H]ow things seem to philosophers, who are alert to relevant distinctions and who know the difference between reporting their intuitions and reporting their considered judgments’ (Korman, 123).

Common sense and intuitive judgments

There are a few different kinds of judgments one might worry about conflicting with.

1. Ordinary beliefs expressed in everyday discourse—‘The island gets much bigger when the tide goes out’.
2. Things non-philosophers are disposed to say when presented with philosophical puzzles or generalizations.
3. ‘[H]ow things seem to philosophers, who are alert to relevant distinctions and who know the difference between reporting their intuitions and reporting their considered judgments’ (Korman, 123).

Korman seems focused on (3). He thinks that these ‘intuitions’ conflict with permissivism, meaning that permissivists need, not just a positive (‘rebutting’) argument for their view, but an independent argument that intuitive judgments on this topic are unreliable (‘undercutting’).

Do permissivist views conflict with everyday belief?

Conservatives are often presented as the friends of common sense, and permissivists as far less friendly (though Korman himself is cautious about this). But, again, it is far from clear whether common sense takes a stand on extraordinary objects. Even granting that common sense does not commit itself to a certain class of extraordinary objects, it remains to be seen whether it is antithetical or merely neutral in regards to the question of their existence. (Fairchild & Hawthorne, 'Against Conservativism', 47)

Two aspects of conservatism

Korman favours a view that accepts the existence of lots of familiar things—people, cars, snowballs, statues, solar systems, . . . —but few or none of the unfamiliar things required by permissivist views.

This kind of conservative will both:

(a) deny the existence of objects having certain ‘weird’ spatial or temporal or modal profiles. EG: deny that there are incars, snowdiscalls, gollyswoggles. . .

(b) deny the existence of *slight variants* of familiar objects (even though these would not have especially weird spatial or temporal or modal profiles). EG: deny that there is an object coincident with the table that is just a little bit more or less ‘tolerant’ than the table as regards which of its parts it could survive having replaced.